Chapter Fifty-Nine

The End of the Papal Monarchy

Between 1301 and 1317, Boniface VIII destroys the Templars, infuriates the king of France, and takes the papacy into exile

As the century turned, Pope Boniface VIII made a massive effort to restore the old power of the papacy; the power it had held back in the days of Innocent IV, more than half a century before.

But fifty years down the road, it was now apparent that Innocent had unintentionally put an expiration date on the power of Saint Peter's heir. He had excommunicated Frederick II, authorized civil war in the Holy Roman Empire, and helped to split Germany, Sicily, and Italy apart; and in doing so, he had deprived the papacy of its strongest potential ally, a Holy Roman Emperor with the power to protect the Church's interest across all three lands.

Now there was no Holy Roman Emperor at all. Sicily was controlled by James of Aragon; southern Italy, the "Kingdom of Naples," by Charles the Lame, son of Charles of Anjou; Germany, by Rudolf of Hapsburg's son Albert. Louis IX's throne was occupied by Philip IV, nicknamed "Philip the Fair" for his good looks; he was much less well-disposed towards the privileges of the Church than his pious grandfather.

And the northern Italian cities were caught in a massive and complicated power struggle between two rival political parties.

These factions, known as Guelph and Ghibelline, had started out in the